THE FINESSE

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

FINESSE LESSON

Probably everybody reading this already knows what a Finesse is and uses them regularly. But a Lesson has to start somewhere, so here goes.

A Finesse is nothing more than an attempt to win a trick with a card which is not the highest one in the suit. It does its magic by being in the right position.

Look at the suit arrangement below.

♦ A Q x

♦ K x x ♦ x x x x

♦ x x x

Only a complete beginner in the South position would try to win two tricks by playing dummy's ♦A and hoping that a kindly opponent would put the ♦K underneath it. Any South who had played a few times would know that to win two tricks she must lead a small ♦x from her hand and play the ♦Q when West plays a low card.
That is a Finesse. A winning one as it happens.

Switch the ♦K from West to East.

♦ A Q x

♦ x x x ♦ K x x x

♦ x x x

Again you have to lead a small ♦x and put on the ♦Q when West plays low.
That is a losing Finesse.
Here is an important fact about the Simple Finesse:

> A SIMPLE FINESSE SUCCEEDS HALF
> THE TIME AND FAILS THE OTHER HALF

Look at those same suit arrangements from a different perspective.

♦ K x x

♦ A Q x ♦ x x x x

♦ x x x

This time South just hopes to win a single trick in the ♦ suit, and she won't do so by leading dummy's ♦K and hoping it sneaks through. No, she must lead a small ♦x from her hand toward the ♦K. If West plays a low card the ♦K will win the trick, and if West plays the ♦A then dummy's ♦K will live to win a

later trick.

A FINESSE WORKS BY LEADING TOWARD HIGH CARDS

The Simple Finesse:

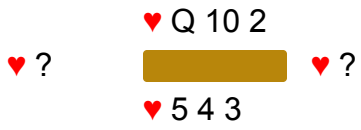
We've already talked about a Simple Finesse without actually defining it.
It is just a finesse which attempts to outfox a single card.

The ♦ A Q x and the ♦ K x x above are both examples of a Simple Finesse.
Here is another.



Now obviously you must lose the ♠A, so your modest goal is to try to win 2 tricks. If West holds the ♠J you can succeed with a Simple Finesse. Lead the ♠3 from your hand and when West plays a low card you insert dummy's ♠10. Either it will win the trick, leaving you and dummy with the ♠K ♠Q combination to drive out the ♠A, or else East will take the ♠10 with his ♠A, leaving you with two high ♠ tricks. Notice that you didn't care who held the ♠A, you just wanted West to hold the ♠J.

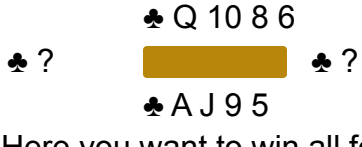
One more (of the thousands possible) before we leave the topic. This one is also a finesse of a Jack.



Things are getting desperate when you need a trick from this combination! Leading a small card with the intention of playing the ♥Q really is desperate - West would have to hold both the ♥ A K for this to work. A better finesse would be to play West for the ♥J and just one of the high honors. So you lead a low card and insert the ♥10, hoping that East must play the ♥A or ♥K to win the trick. Then, later, you play a low card from your hand toward the ♥Q, hoping that West has the other high honor.

Leading a High Card:

Sometimes you will have such good intermediate cards than you don't have to lead a low one for the finesse.



Here you want to win all four ♣ tricks so you will finesse East for the ♣K. But suppose you could only get to dummy one time? No problem. You lead the ♣Q and when East doesn't cover you underplay your ♣J. Still in dummy you play your ♣10, and if East plays low again you underplay your ♣9. You get the idea.

The Double Finesse:

Look at this:

♠ A Q 2
♥ A Q 2

♠ ?
♥ ?



♠ ?
♥ ?

♠ 5 4 3
♥ 5 4 3

This is **NOT** a Double Finesse, it is two Simple Finesses. But the principle is the same.
If you need four tricks here you have to hope that West holds both Kings. Not likely, it will only happen one fourth of the time.
But if you only need three tricks you are in luck. That means that West has to hold either of the Kings (or both) and that will happen three fourths of the time.

Compare that arrangement to this one:

♠ A Q 10

♠ ?



♠ ?

♠ 5 4 3

You play a low card from your hand and finesse the ♠10. If East has to win with the ♠K then you have your two tricks. But even if he wins with the ♠J you still have another chance to get back to your hand and try to finesse West out of his ♠K. If East had both honors you were just unlucky. But if West had both of them you should leave the Bridge table and go to Vegas.

Here is another Double Finesse situation:

♦ A J 10

♦ ?



♦ ?

♦ 5 4 3

This one doesn't look as good because dummy has the ♦J instead of the ♦Q. And sure enough, there is zero chance of making all three tricks here. But, when you are only looking to make two tricks you still have a 75% chance of success.
First finesse the ♦10, and when that loses to one of the big ones try another finesse with the ♦J. You will win two tricks whenever West started with either the ♦K, the ♦Q, or both of them.

The Deep Finesse:

This is sort of between a Simple and a Double Finesse:

♣ A J 9

♣ ?



♣ ?

♣ 5 4 3

Here you hope to win two tricks. If you finesse the ♣J you would win two tricks only when West started with ♣ K Q (x). The better way to play this combination is to lead low toward the ♣9, hoping that West started with either ♣ K 10 x or ♣ Q 10 x.

If you look back at the final example in the Simple Finesse section you will see that it was actually a Deep Finesse. Sometimes the plays overlap the names.

The Two-way Finesse:

The Two-way Finesse is almost always trying to guess a missing Queen.

♥ A J 2

♥ ? ♥ ?

♥ K 10 3

Of course you want all three tricks. Since you can finesse either opponent you should think about the bidding (if any), the opening lead, and any other inferences you might discover to help you decide which way to finesse. If you don't have any clues whatsoever, just pick one and finesse in that direction for a 50% chance.

The Ruffing Finesse:

Most of the time each of the finesse types can be used both in Notrump and Suit contracts.
The Ruffing Finesse can obviously only be used at Suit contracts.

♠ K Q J 2
♥ A 8 6 2

♠ ? ♠ ?
♥ ? ♥ ?

♠ --
♥ K Q J 3

With ♥s as trump you play the ♠K from dummy. If East puts on the ♠A you will ruff, establishing several ♠ winners in dummy. If East plays low you will discard a loser from some other suit.

The Chinese Finesse:

I have no idea how this play got its name. It is more correctly called a Pseudo-Finesse because it isn't a finesse at all, it is just a trick.
First look at this:

♣ A 7 3

♣ ? ♣ ?

♣ Q J 9

You can always win two tricks with this holding. But if you lead the ♣Q West may decide to cover with his ♣K. You could then win the ♣A, finesse East for the ♣10 and perhaps take all three tricks. West can prevent you from doing this simply by not covering your ♣Q but covering the ♣J if you lead it next.

But suppose this is your holding:

♣ A 7 3

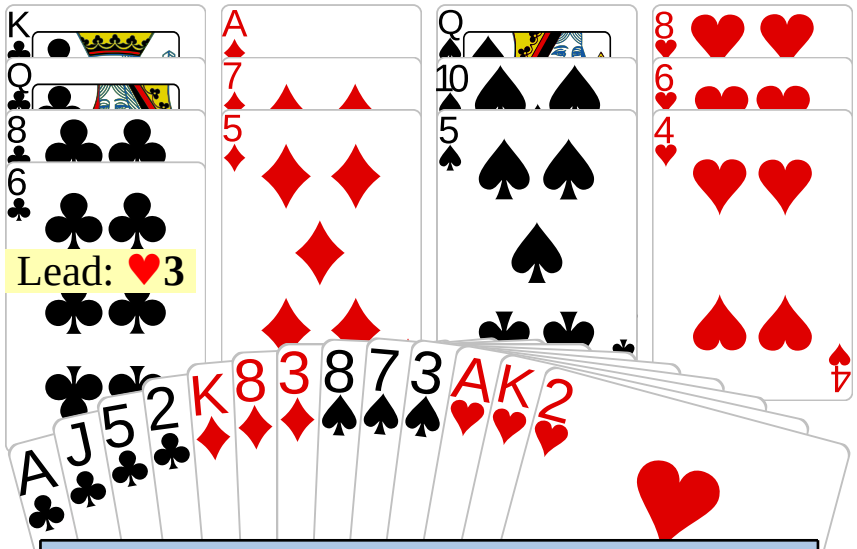
♣ ? ♣ ?

♣ Q 6

If you suspect West holds the ♣K you can try to trick him by leading your ♣Q. This is the Chinese Finesse. If he fears you have ♣ Q J 9 he may duck and wait to cover your ♣J when you lead it.

20 Practice Deals will be worth more than another 1000 words.

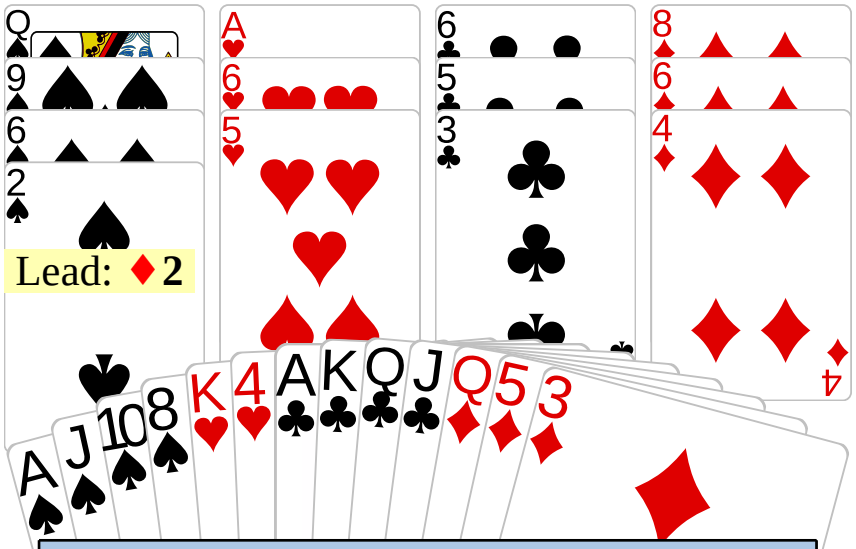
Deal 1 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total

Decide How to Develop Winners			
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play

Deal 2 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total

Decide How to Reduce Losers			
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length

Deal 3 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



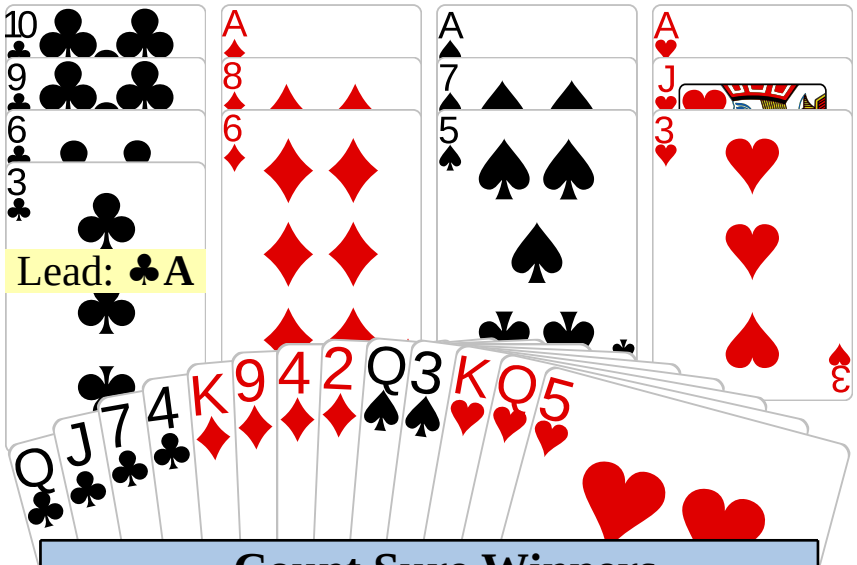
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 5 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 6 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥3

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦2

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥7

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 5
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣A

Board: 6
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦K

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 7 3 ♥ A K 2 ♦ K 8 3 ♣ A J 5 2	
♠ K 9 6 2 ♥ J 9 5 ♦ Q J 6 2 ♣ 10 7	N W E S	♠ A J 4 ♥ Q 10 7 3 ♦ 10 9 4 ♣ 9 4 3
	♠ Q 10 5 ♥ 8 6 4 ♦ A 7 5 ♣ K Q 8 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥3

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥3, dummy plays the ♥4 and West the ♥J.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=4 Total = 8

First things first. Win the first ♥, do not hold up. East's ♥3 indicates he has led a 4-card suit so a hold-up wouldn't help you. And if you did hold up they might pocket their ♥ trick and switch to ♦s, a suit you are no better off in.

You need to get one more winner and it will have to be a ♠ winner.

East plays low.

You could lead toward the ♠Q, winning a trick if East holds BOTH the ♠A and ♠K. Or you could finesse the ♠10, gaining a trick if East holds the ♠J.

The second is more likely. Suppose West wins the ♠K.

West returns a ♥.

East follows and dummy plays the ♥6.

East plays the ♠J.

The ♠Q wins the trick. If the ♠Q wins, take your 9 tricks and run.

Although this doesn't look like a normal A Q finesse it really is about the same.

Whenever the ♠A and ♠K are in different hands, the only thing that matters is the location of the ♠J.

So it is basically a 50% chance.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 5 4 3 ♥ J 9 7 2 ♦ A 10 7 ♣ 10 7	
♠ Q 9 6 2 ♥ A 6 5 ♦ 8 6 4 ♣ 6 5 3		♠ A J 10 8 ♥ K 4 ♦ Q 5 3 ♣ A K Q J
	♠ 7 ♥ Q 10 8 3 ♦ K J 9 2 ♣ 9 8 4 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
3♣	Pass	3♠	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♦2

East is to play 4♠. South leads the ♦2. The defenders win 3 ♦ tricks, then play a ♣.

Losers: ♠ = 0 or 1 ♥ = 0 ♦ = 3 ♣ = 0 Total = 3 or 4

Since you have already lost 3 ♦ tricks you cannot also lose a ♠ trick. That means North will have to have the ♠K and it also means that you will have to be careful with your finessing.

You are in your hand, having won the ♣ switch.

South plays low.

Over to dummy's ♥A.

You lead the ♠Q from dummy and North plays low.

The ♠Q from dummy, and the ♠J (or 10) from your hand when North plays low.

The ♠Q held the trick so you are still in dummy.

North doesn't cover.

The ♠9, playing your ♠8 under it. South shows out on this trick and you are glad you played so carefully. Play one more ♠, finessing North's ♠K again, then play your ♠A and the rest of your winners.

If you had played the ♠Q and carelessly followed with the ♠8 on your first finesse you would have gone down. You would have had to win the second finesse in your hand and would have no dummy entry to let you take the third finesse.

True, the chances of North holding 4 ♠s to the King are pretty small, but it costs you nothing to protect yourself against that holding.

And the rewards are great.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ Q 10 7
♥ 10 5
♦ Q 7 2
♣ A Q 10 8 5

♠ J 8 4
♥ Q J 8 7 3
♦ J 9 4
♣ 9 4



♠ 9 6 5 2
♥ A 9 6 2
♦ 10 8 3
♣ K 3

♠ A K 3
♥ K 4
♦ A K 6 5
♣ J 7 6 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♦
Pass	2♣	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥7

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥7. East takes the ♥A and returns the ♥2.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=1 Total = 8

You need one more winner and ♣s is your best suit. If the ♣K is in West's hand you can finesse it for 12 tricks. But if the ♣K is in East's hand you will lose that trick and at least 4 ♥s.

Before you put all your eggs in the ♣ finesse basket there is one thing you should do first.

West plays low.

You test the ♦ suit: a small one to dummy's ♦Q, then the ♦K and ♦A.

Both defenders followed three times, so your last ♦ is a winner.

You cash it.

Now you have a problem. You have won 5 tricks so far and you have 4 more winners ready to take. So you can take your 9 tricks and run, or you can finesse the ♣ trying for 3 overtricks.

It's your decision, but </br></br>

At Rubber Bridge or Team play it would probably be foolish to risk your contract for the sake of three overtricks.

But at Match Point Pairs the reward would be much greater, a probable very high board. Of course with this layout it might have gotten you a bottom board.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 10 8 5 2 ♥ Q J 9 4 3 ♦ Q 4 ♣ J 9	
♠ Q J 7 4 ♥ A K ♦ 10 8 6 2 ♣ A K Q	N W E S	♠ A 6 3 ♥ 7 5 2 ♦ A 7 5 3 ♣ 10 5 4
	♠ K 9 ♥ 10 8 6 ♦ K J 9 ♣ 8 7 6 3 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♦	Pass	2♦	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♥Q

West is to play 3NT. North leads the ♥Q, dummy plays the ♥2 and South the ♥6.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 7

You need two more winners and ♦s is your longest combined suit. But you can only establish one extra winner in ♦s, and before you could even do that the defenders would have taken a bunch of ♥ tricks.

So you must turn to the ♠s for the extra two winners.

You won the first ♥.

North plays low.

Which ♠ was right? If you play the ♠Q you will go down, even if North has the ♠K. He would cover and you would be held to just 2 ♠ tricks.

The only way to get 3 tricks from this holding is to play South for the ♠K. So play a ♠ to dummy's ♠A and then a small ♠ back toward your ♠ Q J.

South puts on the ♠K.

You are home-free.

You were a little lucky that South's ♠K fell on the second round.

If it had not dropped you would just have played a third round of ♠s, hoping for a 3-3 split in the suit.

You could also have gotten 3 ♠ winners with this distribution.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ Q 3 ♥ K Q 5 ♦ K 9 4 2 ♣ Q J 7 4	
♠ K J 8 4 ♥ 10 9 4 2 ♦ Q J 10 5 ♣ 5	N W E S	♠ 10 9 6 2 ♥ 8 7 6 ♦ 7 3 ♣ A K 8 2
	♠ A 7 5 ♥ A J 3 ♦ A 8 6 ♣ 10 9 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♣A

East plays low.

You enter dummy with a ♥.

West plays low.

A small ♠ toward your ♠Q.

Did it work?

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♣A, then ♣K, ♣2. West follows once, then discards a ♠ and a ♥.

East leads the ♣A, then ♣K, ♣2. West follows once, then discards a ♠ and a ♥.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=3 ♦=2 ♣=2 Total = 8

There are two possibilities for getting an extra winner. If the ♦s are splitting 3-3 you could play ♦A, ♦K and another ♦ and establish the thirteenth ♦ as a winner. Or you could play West for the ♠K and lead toward your ♠Q.

The chance of West holding the ♠K is a little greater than 50%. (it is higher than the usual 50% because we know he started with only one ♣, giving him more spaces for other cards).

The chance of ♦s splitting 3-3 is about 40%.

You might have thought of another possibility; duck a ♦, then play ♦A and ♦K to see if the ♦s split before you try leading toward the ♠Q.

The problem is that you might run into this very distribution. You would establish a ♦ for West and when you played a ♠ from dummy West would jump up with the ♠K and cash his winning ♦ for down 1.

Board 6
South Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ 10 8 7 6 ♥ 10 6 4 2 ♦ 8 2 ♣ 10 7 3	
♠ 9 4 2 ♥ A 8 5 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ A K 6 5		♠ A Q 5 ♥ K J 9 ♦ A 10 4 ♣ Q J 9 2
	♠ K J 3 ♥ Q 7 3 ♦ K Q J 9 5 ♣ 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♦
Pass	Pass	1NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♦K

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♦K, dummy plays the ♦3 and North the ♦2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=4 Total = 8

You only need one more winner. If North has the ♠K or the ♥Q a simple finesse will give you the trick.

There are two problems though. The first one is that if South gets in he may take too many ♦ tricks. But the bigger problem is that North cannot possibly have either of those two high cards. You and dummy together hold 28 HCP and South must surely hold the other 12 since he opened the bidding. Neither simple finesse will work so you must try what is called a Backward Finesse.

Then play four rounds of ♣s ending in your hand.

South continues with the ♦Q; dummy plays the ♦6 and North the ♦8.

South continues with the ♦J; dummy plays the ♦7 and North discards a ♠.

You held up the ♦A until the third round to confirm that North has only 2. He does.

You cash four rounds of ♣s, ending in your hand.

South covers with the ♥Q.

Now play the ♥J. If South doesn't cover, you will let it ride for your ninth trick. But South does cover so you must take dummy's ♥A.

North plays low.

A small ♥ from dummy, finessing the ♥9, hoping North has the ♥10. This is the Backward Finesse.

The Backward Finesse if a pretty rare play. It is against the odds so you only try it when you are absolutely certain that a normal finesse is doomed to fail.

Like this time.

By the way. Those of you with great short-term memories might think they have seen this hand before. Well, you ALMOST have. Deal 8 has an almost identical layout but a much simpler theme. Check it out.